

Program 2 Need Assessment

People in management positions | Target: mid-level managers

Prepared as a research-based, design-ready need assessment using public online data for

India, Indonesia, and South Africa.

Date: April 2026

1. Executive summary

This report assesses the learning need for an online program that improves how mid-level managers communicate with staff. The focus is practical managerial communication: translating strategy into expectations, running developmental 1:1s, giving meaningful feedback, recognizing contribution, communicating change, managing difficult conversations, and creating a psychologically safe communication climate.

Need statement

Managers need a structured communication toolkit for clarity, coaching, feedback, recognition, change, and inclusion. Public evidence indicates that engagement is fragile and that managers are decisive in shaping employee experience; therefore, communication skill development for managers is a business-critical intervention, not a soft add-on.

Assessment element	Summary
Ideal	Managers translate priorities into clear expectations, maintain regular two-way conversations, coach rather than merely instruct, give useful feedback, recognize contribution, and communicate change with transparency and empathy.
Actual	Regional evidence shows low-to-moderate engagement and change pressure. Gallup identifies managers as a major driver of engagement, while ADP and PwC data point to belonging, skills development, leader communication, and change readiness as key issues.
Gap	The main gaps are expectation setting, feedback quality, coaching rhythm, change communication, psychological safety, inclusive communication, and performance conversations.
Program response	A blended online manager program using diagnostics, microlearning, live role practice, 1:1 field experiments, team action sprints, and coaching review.

Scope and assumptions

- Target participants: mid-level managers, team leads, supervisors, and functional managers who manage staff performance and communication climate.
- Delivery mode: online with live practice because managerial communication requires rehearsal, feedback, and real-world transfer.
- Business use case: organizations in India, Indonesia, and South Africa, or companies with comparable engagement, change, and multicultural communication demands.
- Data boundary: public evidence is used to design an informed program; internal validation is needed before full deployment.

2. Evidence base and regional context

This need assessment uses public online evidence as a proxy for likely organizational communication needs in three operating contexts: India, Indonesia, and South Africa. Because the evidence is external, it should be combined with internal HRIS, engagement, quality, and operational data before launch. The findings are directionally useful for designing an online learning program that is region-aware but still adaptable to each company.

Regional workforce indicators relevant to communication need

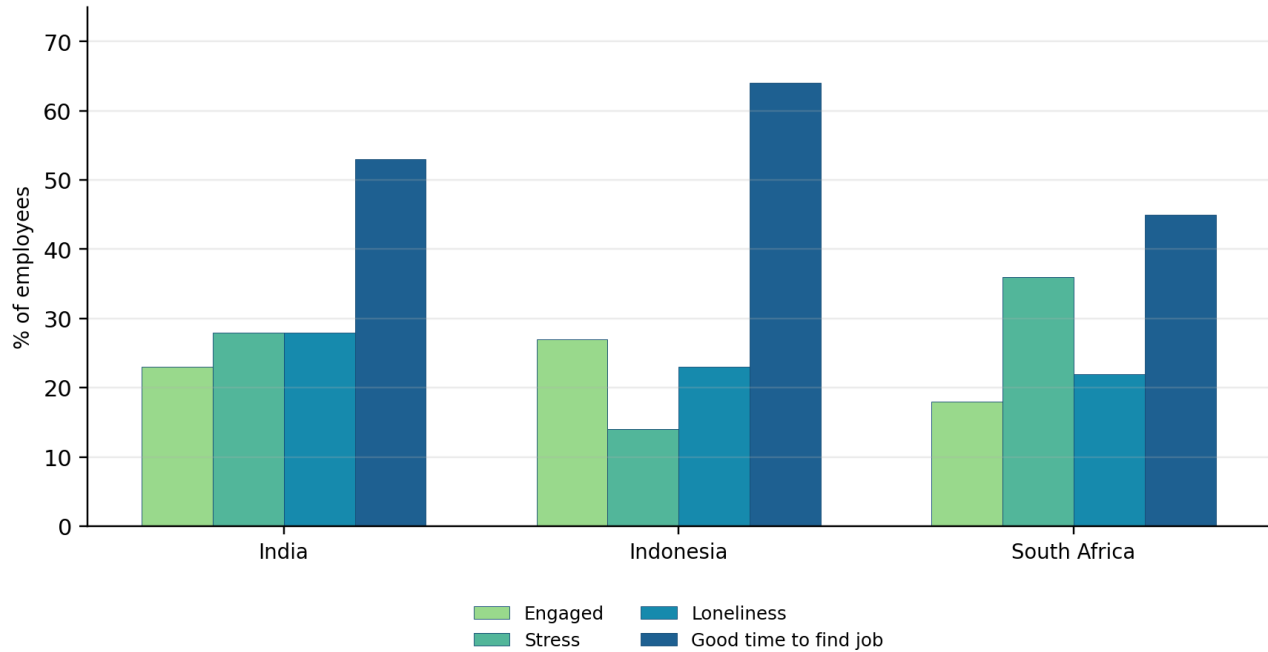


Figure 1. Regional workforce indicators relevant to communication need.

Source note: Gallup country-level data for India, Indonesia, and South Africa [S2][S3][S4].

Context	Actual evidence	Implication for manager-to-staff communication	Sources
India	Gallup reports 23% employee engagement and relatively high daily sadness and anger compared with the global average; ADP reports engagement declined to 19% in 2025 and stresses team belonging and leadership training.	High need for concrete team interfaces, belonging, role clarity, and frequent communication routines. For online design, use collaborative practice and locally relatable cases rather than abstract lectures.	[S2][S12]
Indonesia	Gallup reports 27% engagement. PwC Indonesia reports high change readiness: 91% reacted positively to change, 76% experienced significant role shifts, and 90% were eager to adapt. PwC also emphasizes transparent communication and upskilling.	High readiness for learning, but change pressure means the program must reduce cognitive load, clarify why changes matter, and give practical scripts for daily communication.	[S3][S9]
South Africa	Gallup reports 18% engagement and 36% daily stress. A 2025 systematic review finds workplace conflict is prevalent in multicultural settings and that internal communication can help resolve conflict and motivate performance.	High need for culturally sensitive communication, conflict prevention, psychological safety, and manager/staff awareness of internal communication as a performance lever.	[S4][S10]

Evidence interpretation

The external data shows a common pattern: engagement is not high enough to rely on informal communication alone, while workload, change, cultural diversity, and skill shifts increase the cost of ambiguity. Therefore, the learning need is not merely “better speaking skills”; it is a practical operating discipline for clarity, feedback, handoffs, and trust.

3. Ideal state: what excellent manager-to-staff communication looks like

The ideal manager communicates in a way that makes work meaningful, doable, and discussable. Staff should understand what is expected, why it matters, where priorities sit, how success will be judged, and how to raise concerns. The manager’s role is to create a communication climate in which people feel both supported and accountable.

Manager-to-staff communication performance pathway

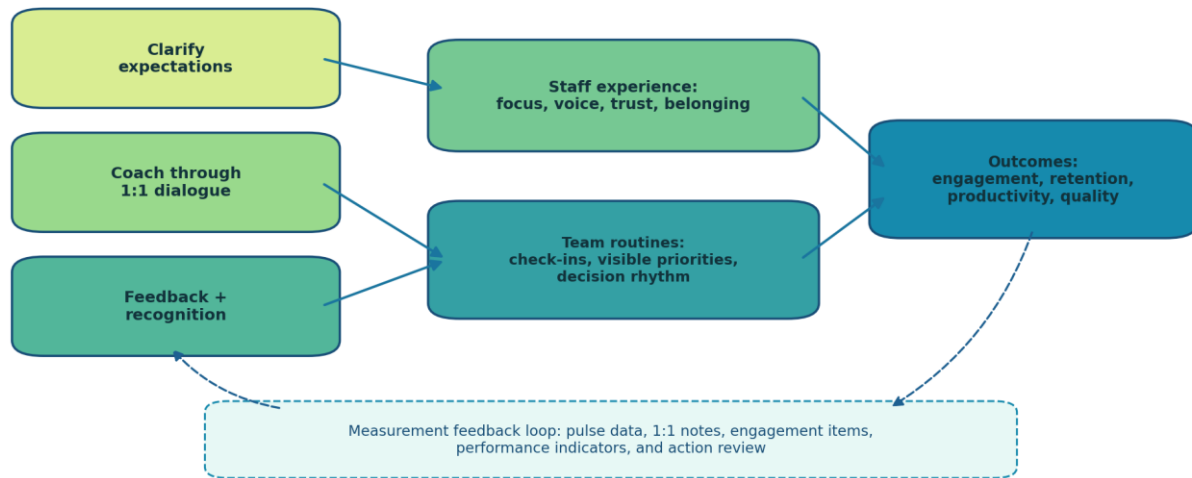


Figure 2. Manager-to-staff communication performance pathway.

Source note: Designed from Gallup engagement and feedback evidence showing the importance of manager conversations, clarity, development, and recognition [S5][S6].

Ideal capability	Performance standard	Observable behavior
Direction and context	Translates organizational priorities into clear team expectations.	Explains why work matters, what success looks like, and how priorities trade off.
Two-way communication	Creates regular space for staff voice, questions, and concerns.	Uses structured 1:1s, team check-ins, open questions, and active listening.
Coaching	Builds employee capability rather than only giving instructions.	Asks discovery questions, removes blockers, and supports development plans.
Feedback	Gives timely, specific, behavior-based feedback that helps improvement.	Uses situation-behavior-impact, feedforward, and agreement on next action.
Recognition	Makes contribution visible and personal.	Recognizes effort, progress, collaboration, and values-aligned behavior.
Change communication	Explains change with transparency, empathy, and practical next steps.	Addresses what changes, what stays stable, impact, support, and decision rationale.
Psychological safety and inclusion	Enables respectful disagreement and belonging across cultural and identity differences.	Invites dissent, repairs miscommunication, and adapts communication style.
Performance accountability	Handles difficult conversations early and constructively.	Aligns expectations, evidence, support, consequences, and follow-up.

4. Actual state: what the public data suggests

The evidence base suggests that managers are operating under pressure: engagement is not robust, change is frequent, employees value development and belonging, and culturally diverse workplaces require more deliberate communication. Managers therefore need more than general leadership awareness; they need practical conversation habits that can be applied every week.

Observed actual condition	Evidence	Manager communication implication	Sources
Manager behavior is a central engagement lever	Gallup reports that managers drive 70% of the variance in team engagement and that engagement depends on purpose, development, caring managers, ongoing conversations, and strengths.	Manager communication training should focus on repeatable conversation routines, not one-time inspirational messaging.	[S5]
Feedback is underused as an engagement tool	Gallup reports that 80% of employees who received meaningful feedback in the past week are fully engaged.	Managers need practice in specific, useful feedback and recognition, with a weekly or biweekly cadence.	[S6]
India shows engagement and	Gallup reports 23% engagement in India; ADP reports	Managers need to intentionally create connection and	[S2][S12]

belonging risk	India engagement declined to 19% in 2025 and points to flexibility, connection, development, team belonging, and local leaders.	clarify growth, especially for younger, hybrid, or distributed staff.	
Indonesia shows high readiness but significant change pressure	PwC Indonesia reports 91% positive response to change, 76% significant role shifts, and emphasizes transparent communication to reduce stress and build trust.	Managers need change-communication scripts: why, impact, support, and staff involvement.	[S3][S9]
South Africa shows multicultural communication and conflict needs	The South Africa systematic review finds conflict is prevalent in multicultural workplaces and highlights cultural training for managers.	Managers need inclusive communication, conflict de-escalation, and psychological safety skills.	[S4][S10]
Skills development is a retention and performance issue	WEF reports that 39% of key skills are expected to change by 2030; ADP reports only 24% of workers globally feel confident about skills for the next job level and 17% strongly agree employers invest in career-advancing skills.	Managers must communicate development pathways and coach staff through skill transitions.	[S7][S13]

5. Gap assessment

The estimated gap is highest where communication directly shapes the daily employee experience: clarity, feedback, coaching rhythm, and psychological safety. The analysis below should be validated through internal manager/staff pulse data, skip-level interviews, attrition analysis, and review of performance-management artifacts.

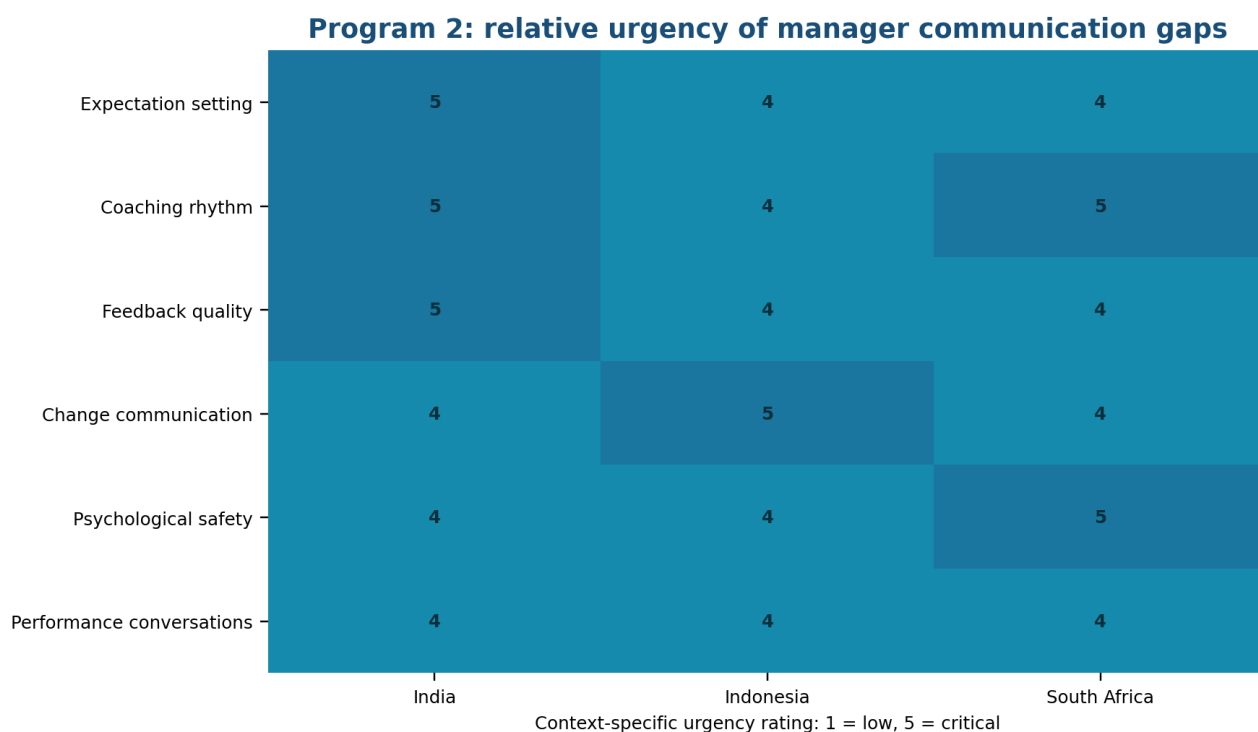


Figure 3. Relative urgency of manager communication gaps.

Source note: Urgency ratings are synthesized from regional data and manager/feedback research [S2][S3][S4][S5][S6][S9][S10][S12][S13].

Ideal versus estimated actual manager capability

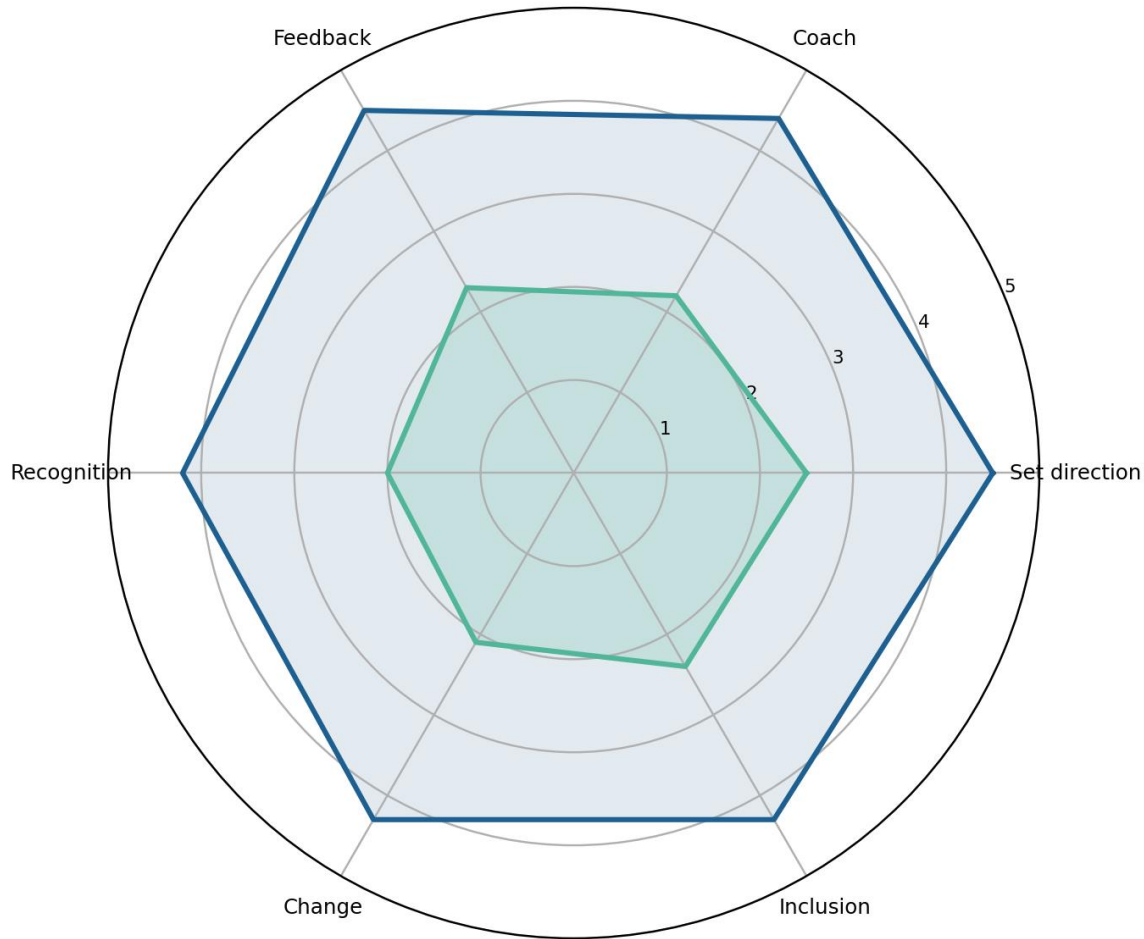


Figure 4. Ideal versus estimated actual manager communication capability.

Source note: Scale: 1 = low consistency; 5 = consistently demonstrated across teams. Replace estimated actual values with internal 180/360 baseline data before rollout.

Gap area	Likely actual state	Business risk	Learning response
Expectation setting	Managers communicate tasks but may not clarify outcome, trade-offs, success criteria, or decision rights.	Staff guess priorities, duplicate work, or escalate late.	Expectation-setting canvas; priority trade-off language; “what good looks like” practice.
Coaching rhythm	1:1s may become status updates or are cancelled under workload pressure.	Development needs and blockers remain invisible until performance suffers.	Monthly 1:1 structure; coaching questions; blocker removal practice.
Feedback quality	Feedback is delayed, vague, too critical, or too praise-light.	Employees do not know what to repeat or change; engagement suffers.	SBI/feedforward model; recognition specificity; difficult feedback role play.
Change communication	Managers pass down announcements without translating impact or listening for concerns.	Change fatigue, rumors, stress, and resistance increase.	Change message map: why, what, impact, support, involvement, next check-in.
Psychological safety and inclusion	Staff may not speak up across hierarchy, culture, language, or identity differences.	Risks stay hidden; disagreements become personal or passive.	Inclusive meeting facilitation, dissent invitation, repair statements, cultural humility.
Performance conversations	Managers avoid difficult conversations or over-rely on authority.	Accountability is inconsistent, trust erodes, and documentation is weak.	Evidence-based conversation planner; support/consequence balance; follow-up contract.

6. Recommended online learning program

The recommended manager program is a seven-week online journey. It starts with a diagnostic, then moves through communication routines that managers can immediately test with their own staff. The program should include live role practice because managers often know what good communication sounds like in theory but need rehearsal for emotionally complex moments.

Program 2 online learning journey



Learning transfer mechanism: workplace assignments, manager/peer observation, digital nudges, reflection journal, and post-program action sprint

Figure 5. Program 2 online learning journey.

Source note: The learning journey uses diagnostics, practice, field experiments, and team action sprints to promote transfer.

Module	Content focus	Learning outcome	Online activity
0. Manager diagnostic	Self-assessment, staff pulse items, communication incident reflection.	Identify the manager's communication pattern and team need.	20-min diagnostic + optional 180 pulse.
1. Communication role of the manager	How manager communication shapes engagement, trust, and execution.	Managers connect daily conversations to engagement and performance outcomes.	Micro-lesson + reflection.
2. Set direction and expectations	Context, priorities, decision rights, definition of done, and check-back.	Managers practice translating a vague business priority into staff clarity.	Scenario rewrite + peer critique.
3. Run developmental 1:1s	Listening, coaching questions, blockers, development, and follow-up.	Managers conduct a 1:1 that balances performance and support.	Live role practice + field experiment.
4. Feedback and recognition	Specific positive feedback, corrective feedback, feedforward, and recognition.	Managers give feedback staff can act on and repeat.	Role practice with rubric.
5. Communicate change and reduce stress	Transparent change communication, emotions, uncertainty, and involvement.	Managers explain change while inviting voice and maintaining direction.	Change message map + practice.
6. Inclusive communication and conflict	Psychological safety, cultural humility, disagreement, and repair.	Managers facilitate respectful challenge and de-escalate tension.	Simulation + facilitator feedback.
7. Capstone team action sprint	Manager applies two routines with their team and reviews evidence.	Managers present behavior change, evidence, and sustainment plan.	Team experiment + coach review.

7. Implementation and transfer workflow

Phase	Action	Owner	Timing
Before launch	Collect baseline: staff pulse on clarity, feedback, recognition, manager approachability, development, and psychological safety; review attrition and performance conversation quality.	HRBP + L&D + business leaders	2-3 weeks
Cohort setup	Group managers by level and operational reality; invite senior sponsor to reinforce that communication routines are expected management practice.	L&D program owner	1 week
During modules	Each manager applies a weekly conversation tool with their own team and logs evidence.	Participant + direct manager	7 weeks
Manager support	Provide office hours, peer triads, and digital nudges before key team conversations.	Facilitator + coach	During program

After program	Run 60-day team action sprint with two routines: recurring 1:1s and expectation-setting for priorities.	Manager + staff team	60 days
Sustainment	Embed manager communication items in performance expectations; review team-level pulse results quarterly.	HR + senior leaders	Quarterly

8. Evaluation plan

Manager communication training must be evaluated through staff experience, not manager satisfaction alone. The strongest evidence of success will be increased staff clarity, improved feedback frequency and quality, higher psychological safety, and reduced people-risk indicators.

Program 2 measurement dashboard targets



Figure 6. Suggested Program 2 measurement dashboard.

Source note: Targets are suggested starting points; each organization should calibrate them using internal baseline data.

Level	What to measure	Method	Timing
Reaction	Manager perceived relevance, psychological safety of practice, confidence in tools.	Post-module pulse.	Each module
Learning	Ability to set expectations, run 1:1s, give feedback, communicate change, and facilitate conflict.	Scenario-based assessment and role-play rubric.	Weeks 2, 4, 6
Behavior	Observed 1:1 cadence, feedback frequency, staff clarity, team meeting quality, recognition behavior.	Staff pulse, manager logs, peer triad review.	30 and 60 days
Impact	Engagement items, retention risk, performance issue cycle time, reduced avoidable escalations.	People analytics + team metrics.	90 and 180 days

9. Internal validation instruments

Recommended baseline questions for a company-specific manager communication need assessment:

Dimension	Survey/interview item
Expectation clarity	My manager helps me understand what is expected, why it matters, and how success will be evaluated.
Two-way dialogue	I have regular opportunities to ask questions, raise concerns, and discuss obstacles with my manager.
Feedback quality	The feedback I receive from my manager is specific, timely, and useful for improving my work.
Recognition	My manager recognizes contributions in a way that feels specific and meaningful.
Change communication	When priorities change, my manager explains the reason, impact, and next steps clearly.
Psychological safety	I can respectfully disagree with my manager or team without fear of negative consequences.
Development	My manager discusses my growth and helps me identify skills needed for the future.

References and online resources

Citation format in this report uses bracketed source IDs such as [S2]. The URLs below were used for evidence and can be opened directly from the Word file.

[S1] Gallup. State of the Global Workplace 2026. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349484/state-of-the-global-workplace.aspx>

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[S2] Gallup. India Country-Level Data, State of the Global Workplace. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/705650/state-global-workplace-india-country-level-data.aspx>

India engagement, wellbeing, daily stress/anger/sadness/loneliness, and job-climate data.

[S3] Gallup. Indonesia Country-Level Data, State of the Global Workplace. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/705674/state-global-workplace-indonesia-country-level-data.aspx>

Indonesia engagement, wellbeing, daily stress/anger/sadness/loneliness, and job-climate data.

[S4] Gallup. South Africa Country-Level Data, State of the Global Workplace. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/707162/state-global-workplace-south-africa-country-level-data.aspx>

South Africa engagement, wellbeing, daily stress/anger/sadness/loneliness, and job-climate data.

[S5] Gallup. How to Improve Employee Engagement in the Workplace. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/285674/improve-employee-engagement-workplace.aspx>

Manager influence, Q12 model, drivers of engagement, and team conversations.

[S6] Gallup. How Effective Feedback Fuels Performance. <https://www.gallup.com/workplace/357764/fast-feedback-fuels-performance.aspx>

Meaningful weekly feedback and engagement link.

[S7] World Economic Forum. Future of Jobs Report 2025. <https://www.weforum.org/stories/2025/01/future-of-jobs-report-2025-jobs-of-the-future-and-the-skills-you-need-to-get-them/>

Skill disruption and rising importance of leadership, social influence, agility, and lifelong learning.

[S8] PwC. Asia Pacific Workforce Hopes and Fears Survey 2024. <https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/about/pwc-asia-pacific/hopes-and-fears.html>

Change, workload, team-structure changes, retention risk, and learning opportunity findings.

[S9] PwC Indonesia. Indonesia Hopes and Fears 2024. <https://www.pwc.com/id/en/pwc-publications/services-publications/consulting/indonesia-hopes-and-fears-2024.html>

Indonesia-specific worker readiness, stress from change, upskilling and transparent communication recommendations.

[S10] Motsamai, P.F.T. & Onyenankeya, K. Employee perceptions of internal communication in culturally diverse workplaces in South Africa: A systematic literature review. Social Sciences & Humanities Open, 2025. <https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S2590291125003171>

South Africa multicultural communication, conflict, and cultural training implications.

[S12] ADP Research. India Workforce Engagement Plummets to 19% in 2025. <https://in.adp.com/about-adp/press-centre/india-workforce-engagement-plummets-to-19-percent-in-2025.aspx>

India engagement decline, work-location mix, team belonging, and leadership training implications.

[S13] ADP Research. People at Work 2025: A Global Workforce View. <https://hk.adp.com/resources/insights/people-at-work-2025-a-global-workforce-view.aspx>

Global skills-development confidence, employer investment in skills, engagement, career growth, and workplace monitoring themes.